DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Is Night Different? Impurity, Midnight and Sleep

Derech Hashem 4:6:1-2

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 6, paragraphs 1-2 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 3 March 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

The order of the day

This chapter is called "the details of the order of the day and of prayer". The Rabbi placed it in the structure of Part 4: after Torah study, the service of God divides into constant misvot (love and fear), seasonal ones (the festivals), circumstantial ones (like a parapet on a roof) and daily ones. Having discussed Shema and the purpose of prayer, the Ramhal now explains the other things we do every day, from the moment we wake up.

Night belongs to the forces of impurity (paragraph 1)

God in His wisdom arranged that the night is the time when the forces of impurity have authority and can spread through the world. As learned before, there must be good and bad in the world, and God gave the bad its territory: the night. So He arranged that people sleep at home and rest at night, and go out to work in the day, as David says in Tehillim 104, which is said on Rosh Hodesh: "The sun rises... man goes out to his work until evening."

The Rabbi noted this is the second time the Ramhal has told us that night is for sleeping. "Today we're in a different world, but it's not ideal." He added that sleep in the early evening was natural before electric light; the special people would then wake at midnight.

This is also why the Mishnah warns that someone who walks alone at night, with his mind not on anything worthwhile, endangers himself: it is night, he is alone, and he has no protection. If he is learning Torah, the Torah protects him.

Midnight changes everything

The domination of the forces of impurity lasts only for the first part of the night, until midnight. At midnight a new influence of divine will comes into all the worlds, the power of the evil forces is removed, and the emanation of the day begins to awaken until sunrise.

The Rabbi drew several practical points from this:

- Netilat yadayim: following the Ben Ish Hai, someone who stays up until after midnight and only then goes to sleep does not say the blessing on washing his hands when he wakes. The impurity that requires the washing rests only on someone who slept in the first half of the night. A participant asked about the Rambam's view, that the washing is for cleanliness before prayer, and the Rabbi agreed that on that view any sleep would be the same.
- Selihot: they may be said from midnight because mercy is already coming, but the best time is at dawn, the end of the night and the beginning of the day, when the illumination really emerges.
- King David's harp hung over his bed, and the north wind woke him at midnight; he knew it was a special time.
- The ideal routine of the hakhamim: sleep after Arvit, get up after six hours or so, learn, and then pray Shaharit at sunrise.

Day for good, night for bad (paragraph 2)

The Ramhal explains that the forces ruling at night and being driven out by day is part of the natural order, quite apart from what human beings do to strengthen or weaken them. God decided that in one part of time evil can spread, which also allows people to do evil; and in another part, the day, its authority is removed, an invitation to do good. Day and night are two fixed times prepared for human choice.

The Rabbi shared his own feeling: in the daytime a person feels happier, more energised and more connected to God, whereas at night things feel darker. A participant observed that in summer we sleep through hours of daylight and stay up at night, exposing ourselves the most; the Rabbi noted the very short winter days in England. Asked whether these forces begin at sunset or at nightfall, he said that when night begins is the age-old question "which no one knows the answer to."

Why the impurity rests on a sleeper

At night the forces of evil have more authority, and they spread over a person lying asleep because he is static. The Rabbi's analogy was snow: it settles on what stays still. Someone walking around all night is exposed, but it is harder for anything to take hold of him.

This is why the halachah is that after a short nap of less than half an hour one does not need to wash one's hands: the impurity has not had time to take hold. "Little halachot are based on our understanding of how the world runs." There are different opinions on the exact time, but the practice is half an hour.

The Ramhal adds that how much impurity rests on a person depends on how much materialism he allows himself. That is why it is said that the early hasidim did not need to wash their hands in the morning. And the Ben Ish Hai explains that on Yom Kippur we wash only to the knuckles, because we are holy and less can reach us. A participant added that the yeser hara works the same way as materialism, and the Rabbi agreed.

A participant asked about places in the far north where it is light or dark for 24 hours. The Rabbi answered that the Torah was given to be practised in the Land of Israel, as the Ramban says; even England is not really the place, with Sukkot in the rain and very late summer Shabbatot.

Sleep, a taste of death

As learned in Part 3, in sleep parts of the soul depart, and sleep is one sixtieth of death. Being closer to death, a person has more darkness and is more susceptible.

Why does the impurity rest on the hands? The mekubalim explain that impurity always rests on the extremities. The Ben Ish Hai writes that this is why the kohanim washed their feet as well, and why before Shabbat one washes face, hands and feet. The Rabbi added an idea from one of his teachers: the ground is what makes us feel physical and in control (think of a rollercoaster), and the hands and feet are what touch the physical world.

Summary

- God gave the forces of impurity authority at night, which is why we sleep at night and work by day.
- At midnight their power ends and the light of the day begins to emerge; selihot are best at dawn.
- Someone who first sleeps after midnight does not bless on netilat yadayim, following the Ben Ish Hai.
- Impurity settles on a sleeper because he is still, and more so the more materialistic he is.
- It rests on the extremities, the hands and feet, which connect us to the physical world.

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